

Chapter 2: Discipline

What Kind of Science is Sociology?

Introduction

Here is one (very negative) view about the current state of Sociology:

According to Ray Rodrigues, chancellor of the state university system, Florida lawmakers began eyeing general education as a target of reform after complaints from parents. Their children would come home for Thanksgiving break during their first semester in college and would “be communicating cultural Marxism”...Under SB 266 [a Florida state law intended to eliminate “woke” ideology], courses that count toward general-education credit should “promote and preserve the constitutional republic” through “traditional, historically accurate” coursework. The law also says that “core courses” may not “distort significant historical events,” “include a curriculum that teaches identity politics,” or be based on theories that systemic racism, sexism, oppression, and privilege are inherent in American institutions.¹

There is much to unpack in this statement. For now, we will leave aside the meaning of “cultural Marxism.”² We will also only briefly note that colleges explicitly advertise themselves as places to “push boundaries, challenge assumptions and redefine what’s possible,”³ so one would *expect* young people to *want* to discuss new and interesting ideas with their family. We will

¹ “Is Sociology Being Saved — or Debased — in Florida?” *Chronicle of Higher Education*, March 16, 2026.

² I seriously doubt that Rodrigues and his allies are reading Gramsci, Lukacs, or Benjamin, and instead, are simply using “cultural Marxism” as a catch-all for ideologies they don’t like. See A.J.A. Woods, *The Cultural Marxism Conspiracy*, Verso, 2026.

³ [Stony Brook’s Webpage](#), accessed June 27th, 2026.

also only glancingly note that “promot[ing] and preserv[ing] the constitutional republic” is *itself* an ideological goal, and that pursuing it explicitly could and would bias our understanding of society just like an explicitly “woke” one would.

Instead, I want to take aim at what seems to be a foundational assumption of those criticizing sociology: that there is a way to pursue a completely unbiased, objective, neutral study of society. The authors of the Florida state law imply, by claiming to cleanse University curriculum of “distortions,” that there *is* an objective, true, and indisputable nature of society and history that is like the things we know about the physical history of the universe, biological dynamics, or the engineering of the material environment.

As you will see in this chapter, at a very basic level sociology (and the rest of the social sciences) do not work this way. This is because they take as their central object **people in society**, and since people *react* to their understandings about the world and the meaning they take from it, they need to be studied in a different way than rocks, planets, and pathogens. However, this does *not* mean that the social sciences and particularly sociology are therefore simply a realm where we assert opinions and call them facts; instead, it means that we have a wide inventory of careful, systematic ways of understanding the world, and our job here in part is to introduce them.

What Is A Science?

To answer the question “what kind of science is sociology?”, we need to answer a prior question: just what makes a science a *science*?

What Is A Theory?

What Is A Hypothesis?

What Is Evidence?

What Is A Method?

Some Tensions In A Pluralistic Science

**A Smorgasbord Of Contemporary Methods
in Sociology**